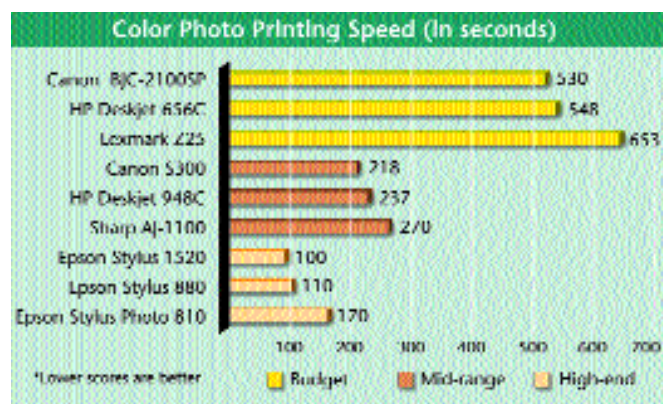




high-end printer look for a printing speed of under 20 seconds.

Here, the Epson Stylus Photo 810 was the only printer that took over 30 seconds for the black and white text print. The Canon S4500, Epson Stylus 880 and the Lexmark Z65N could print the document in 12 seconds flat—the page was out even before we could get up and take a look at the printer!

The colour document print test was a different story however. The Epson Stylus 1520 came to the fore here, taking 1 minute 40 seconds to print the full colour photo. It was followed closely by the Epson Stylus 880, which took 1 minute 50 seconds. The rest were over a minute slower and nowhere in the reckoning.

The greyscale photo test once again proved what has been observed all along—the Lexmark models rule the roost when it comes to black and white printing. The Lexmark Z65N finished printing the greyscale photo in a mere 29 seconds—the fastest recorded in the entire comparison test.

Text printing quality: But speed is not everything. If the output is marred by smears, smudges, misaligned text and jagged edges, then speed cuts no ice. The best printers are those that maintain the right balance of quality and speed and preferably compromise on speed in favour of quality. As a measure of how the scores stack up, 1 out of 5 means that the text is readable but has visible smudges, text is misaligned, or the text isn't crisp enough. A score of 3 out of 5 should be considered normal and neat; printers that score 4 and above should be considered exceptionally good with good black level depth and no jagged edges on the text.

In the budget range of printers, the Canon BJC-2100SP delivered crisp text output and was able to reproduce fonts exactly as they appear on the screen. It scored a neat 3.5. The Canon S200SP came in a close second, scoring 3.4.

The Lexmark series of printers, which logged a consistently fast speed when printing in black and white mode, scored poorly here. The Lexmark Z25 scored only 1.7 and the Z13 scored only 1.4. The Z35, which was also the fastest among the lot, was the only printer from the Lexmark series to score a fairly decent 2.7.

The text quality was markedly better in the mid-range printers. Newcomer Sharp AJ-1100 logged the highest score—it scored a phenomenally high 4.4, the highest in the comparison test. This model was also amongst the fastest in the text speed test, which makes it a great choice for pure text printouts.

The HP Deskjet 920C also did well, scoring a very impressive 4.2—the text was 'jet' black with no smudging, smearing or jaggedness. The Canon S300 too came close with a score of 3.8. If you consider the speed (15 seconds) at which it prints, it

certainly is a force to reckon with.

If you are looking for high speed without sacrificing quality, a high-end printer is what you need. If you are spending so much money then you should not accept anything which scores less than 3.

The HP Deskjet 970CXi and the Epson Stylus Photo 810 were amongst the best here, with a score of 3.8 each. The Canon S4500 has probably the best combination of speed and text quality. It scored a neat 3.5 in text quality and produced consistent quality at an amazing print speed (12 seconds). The only poor performer here was the Epson Stylus 895—the text was heavily jagged and misaligned. We tested this printer repeatedly with two sets of new cartridges, but there was no improvement in the results.

Photo printing quality: This one is a torture test. Printing an image at high resolutions or best possible quality puts a printer through tremendous stress. Good overall colour reproduction, contrast, ability to render detail, consistency across the page and most importantly, no smudging—the printer has to do it all. Since a typical photograph has enormous colour variations with no blank spaces, the printer head gets no respite. For instance, when printing text, it would get time off when it encounters spaces between words. Even when printing a block of single colour, it would be less taxing on the printer head. But when it has to jump from colour to colour with no pause in between, the printer gets stressed.

On the whole, the image quality in the budget category was average to above average. The skin colour in the photo was never truly reproduced and was a little faded in all the test prints.

A curious observation: the highest scorer and the lowest scorer were from the same company—the Canon S200SP (a score of 7) and the Canon BJC-2100SP (a score of 4.2), respectively. The photo reproduction in the S200SP was sharp and vivid. There were minimal smudges, the specular effects on the bangle were crystal clear and you could even count the model's teeth! The Canon BJC-2100SP on the other hand showed bands throughout



Selecting the Right Paper

The paper you use greatly determines the print quality.

Standard quality paper doesn't provide as crisp and bright an image as paper made specially for a particular inkjet printer. The main factors that affect paper quality are:

Brightness of paper: This is normally determined by the smoothness of the paper. A coarse sheet of paper will scatter light in different directions, whereas smooth paper will reflect more of the light back in the same direction. This makes the paper appear brighter, which in turn makes images on the paper appear brighter. The finish may be described as high gloss, gloss, soft gloss, or semi-gloss, each reflecting the amount of shine.

Absorption: When the printer sprays ink onto the paper, it should stay in a tight, symmetrical dot. If the ink is absorbed too much into the paper, the dot will spread out in an irregular fashion and the result is fuzzy images and text. The coating on photo papers gives the printed photos the look and feel of photographic prints. Because the coating keeps the paper from readily absorbing the ink, some glossy papers dry slowly. However, quick-dry gloss finishes are common today.